Interactional Meta–discourse in Thai EFL Student Essays: A Corpus–Based Study

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Abstract

Interactional meta–discourse, including hedges and boosters, attitude and engagement markers, and self–mentions, is a useful device for expressing stance and building relationships with readers. This study investigated the use of interactional meta–discourse in essays written by Thai EFL university students and explored students' and instructors' perspectives on its use in academic writing. A corpus–based approach was employed to analyze 60 student essays (30 from a public university and 30 from a private university), comprising 23,061 words (PU = 11683; PVU = 11,378), using Hyland's (2005) interactional meta–discourse framework. Additionally, in–depth interviews were conducted with five students and five instructors to examine how students use these devices in essay writing and to inform instructional guidelines. The results showed that self–mentions were the most frequently used interactional meta–discourse feature, whereas attitude markers were the least frequent across both corpora. PU students also used boosters more often than PVU students. Interview findings revealed that students used these features according to classroom writing conventions rather than rhetorical awareness, and that instructors provided limited explicit instruction on interactional meta–discourse. These findings underscore the need for explicit instruction and instructional scaffolding to enhance students' awareness of writer stance and reader engagement in academic writing. Corpus analysis results, integrated with interview data in the Thai EFL context, provide empirical evidence for understanding interactional meta–discourse and offer practical implications for academic writing pedagogy.

Keywords: epistemic modality; hedges; boosters; attitude markers; engagement markers; self–mentions; interactional meta–discourse

Introduction

Academic writing is a fundamental means of communication that enables students to demonstrate their critical thinking, construct arguments, and participate in academic discourse. Good writing is not just about grammatical accuracy; it also includes the writer's ability to organize ideas logically, use meaningful discourse structures, and apply rhetorical strategies to meet intercultural expectations. Therefore, developing effective writing skills is essential for helping students express their ideas meaningfully.

Academic discourse is the use of language for academic purposes across genres such as textbooks, research articles, and seminars. It reflects the values and conventions of academic disciplines through academic vocabulary, structured arguments, and evidence–based claims. Therefore, it is essential that learners understand how language use varies by context, audience, and purpose. Effective academic discourse is essential for success in academic and professional settings because it uses discursive devices that help writers express ideas, build arguments, and engage readers. In this study, these devices refer to interactional meta–discourse features. including attitude markers, engagement markers, and self–mentions. These features allow writers to express their stance, indicate levels of certainty, and build relationships with readers.

For EFL learners, especially at the university level, effective use of interactional meta–discourse, from basic to advanced levels, helps writers develop a strong academic voice and convey meaning clearly. Hedges and boosters, for example, enable writers to express varying degrees of certainty, while attitude markers, engagement markers, and self–mentions allow writers to express evaluation, involve readers, and establish authorial presence (Hyland, 2005, 2009; Hyland & Tse, 2004). These resources therefore serve as important interpersonal tools in academic discourse, enabling writers to negotiate claims, express stance, and align with disciplinary expectations. However, studies of Thai EFL writing have often focused on grammatical accuracy, vocabulary, organization, or general discourse features rather than systematically examining interactional meta–discourse and the reasons for students' choices.

However, several studies have reported that EFL students often struggle to use interactional meta–discourse due to limited linguistic proficiency, limited awareness of rhetorical functions, and instructional practices that may not explicitly emphasize these features (Liu & Tseng, 2021; Liu & Stapleton, 2020). For example, in Asian EFL contexts, students are likely to overuse or underuse epistemic markers, which can make their writing unpersuasive and unclear (Qin & Uccelli, 2019).

Furthermore, in some countries, such as China and Thailand, indirect, harmonious language and uncertainty avoidance are characteristic, leading students to prefer tentative expressions or limited modality (Hu & Li, 2015). L2 writers may also display stronger subjectivity or rely on different modality patterns due to L1 influence and rhetorical conventions (Alonso, 2019; Dewi et al., 2024; Incharoensak & Gampper, 2019; Karahan, 2022; Liu & Stapleton, 2020; Ritonga et al., 2025).

Despite the importance of interactional meta–discourse in academic writing, research on Thai EFL students' use of it remains limited. This study systematically analyzes Thai EFL students' use of hedges and boosters, attitude markers, engagement markers, and self–mentions, seeking to provide a more comprehensive account of interactional meta–discourse in the Thai EFL context. The findings may benefit EFL teachers and curriculum designers by identifying areas that require greater attention and informing the development of explicit instruction, targeted teaching materials, and instructional scaffolding to enhance students' awareness of stance and reader engagement in academic writing.

Research Objectives

The objectives of this study are to:

(1) examine the frequency and distribution of interactional meta–discourse features in essays written by EFL students at a public university and a private university;

(2) explore students' and instructors' awareness, perceptions, and reported practices regarding the use of interactional meta–discourse in academic writing; and

(3) provide pedagogical strategies, grounded in corpus and interview findings, to assist EFL instructors in teaching interactional meta–discourse.

Scope of Research

Content of the study: The framework of this study is primarily based on the interactional functions in Hyland's model of academic meta–discourse, which allows writers to involve readers in the texts, as follows:

Categories	Function	Recourses
Interactional	**Involve the readers in the argument.**	
Hedges	Withhold writers' full commitment to propositions	might/perhaps/possible/about, etc.
Boosters	Emphasize force or the writer's certainty in propositions	In fact / definitely/ It is clear that, etc.
Attitude markers	Express the writer's attitude to the proposition	Unfortunately / agree/ surprisingly, etc.
Engagement markers	Explicitly refer to or build a relationship with the readers	consider/note that/you can see that, etc.
Self–mentions	Explicit reference to the author(s)	I/ we/ my/our

Participants: The participants in the present study included: (1) University students learning English as a Foreign Language (EFL) enrolled in an academic writing course during the first semester of the 2025 academic year; (2) English language instructors selected for their experience teaching academic writing and for holding at least a master's degree in ELT, Teaching English to Speakers of Other Languages (TESOL), Teaching English as a Foreign Language (TEFL), Teaching English as a Second Language (ESL), Linguistics, Second Language Acquisition (SLA), or related fields.

Area: The present study was conducted at higher education institutions in Udon Thani, including one public and one private university that offer programs in Business English, English Language Teaching (ELT), and Linguistics, with a focus on teaching English as a second or foreign language (ESL/EFL).

Time: This study was conducted from May 2025 to April 2026.

Literature Review

Academic Discourse

Academic discourse refers to how language is used within academic communities to communicate knowledge across genres such as essays, textbooks, research articles, and presentations. This involves presenting information and establishing relationships between writers and readers through various discursive strategies (Hyland, 2011; Swales, 2004). Additionally, from the perspective of Systemic Functional Linguistics, academic discourse has three meta–functions: ideational, interpersonal, and textual. The ideational meta–function concerns the representation of knowledge, the interpersonal meta–function reflects writers' stance and attitudes, and the textual meta–function organizes information into coherent texts. In the present study, the interpersonal dimension is particularly relevant to the study of meta–discourse and epistemic modality.

Academic discourse has become increasingly important for three main reasons: (1) students at higher education institutions are required to develop academic literacy and English for Academic Purposes (EAP) competencies; (2) English is widely used in international contexts, serves as a medium for constructing arguments and for publication, and makes academic writing essential for scholarly participation; and (3) academic writing persuades readers and contributes new knowledge rather than merely presenting facts. Therefore, academic communities require both linguistic competence and awareness of disciplinary expectations.

Meta–discourse

Meta–discourse is a central concept in academic discourse. Hyland and Tse define meta–discourse as linguistic resources that help writers organize texts, express attitudes, establish credibility, and engage readers. They also explain that there are three key principles of meta–discourse: (1) meta–discourse is distinct from propositional content because it comments on information rather than introducing new information; (2) it facilitates interaction between writers and readers by expressing attitudes, certainty, and engagement; and (3) it has both internal textual connections and external links to disciplinary knowledge and shared understandings. Hyland further explains that interactive resources help organize texts and guide readers through transitions by using frame markers, endophoric markers, evidentials, and code glosses, while interactional resources allow writers to express stance and involve readers in the discourse, enabling writers to position themselves in relation to knowledge claims and to immediately engage readers in the construction of meaning.

Epistemic Modality in Academic Discourse

Epistemic modality (EM) is an important interactional meta–discourse resource that reflects writers' degrees of commitment to propositions, conveys their evaluations of knowledge claims, and facilitates interaction with readers. According to Vázquez and Giner, epistemic modality markers indicate either commitment to propositions (boosters) or lack of commitment (hedges). EM is influenced by writers' linguistic and cultural backgrounds and reflects broader sociocultural values such as politeness, uncertainty avoidance, and individualism.

Hyland's (2005) interactional framework

(1) Hedges are expressions that allow writers to withhold full commitment to propositions and acknowledge alternative viewpoints. Common hedging devices include modal verbs, reporting verbs, cognitive verbs, linking verbs, adverbs, adjectives, and nouns that convey probability or

uncertainty. These devices help writers express caution, tentativeness, openness to interpretation, and politeness strategies that reduce the risk of overstatement and maintain interpersonal harmony.

(2) Boosters are linguistic devices that express certainty, strengthen claims, demonstrate confidence in propositions, and emphasize commitment to the truth of a statement. Common boosters include verbs (show, demonstrate, establish), adverbs (clearly, obviously), and modal verbs (must, will). These resources reinforce the credibility of arguments and help writers establish solidarity with readers. (Swales, 2004).

(3) Attitude markers (unfortunately, surprisingly, remarkably) convey writers' evaluations, emotions, and judgments about propositions.

(4) Engagement markers serve as resources that involve readers through directives, questions, appeals to shared knowledge, and second–person references. These markers foster a more dialogic relationship between writers and readers.

(5) Self–mentions are references to the writer using first–person pronouns and possessive adjectives, such as I, we, my, and our (Hyland, 2005). They contribute to the construction of authorial identity and writer presence in academic discourse.

Interactional meta–discourse.

Interactional meta–discourse is shaped by cultural values. Research by Hofstede suggests that dimensions such as uncertainty avoidance, individualism–collectivism, and indirectness vary across cultures. For example, writers from high–uncertainty–avoidance cultures tend to use stronger markers of certainty, whereas those from collectivist cultures may prefer less individualized forms of self–representation.

Research Methodology

This mixed–methods, corpus–based research design examined five interactional features using Hyland's (2005) framework. Quantitative and qualitative data were collected from students' essays and semi–structured interviews to provide a broader understanding of authentic language use in academic writing. This study was approved by the Human Research Ethics Committee of the Research and Development Institute at Udon Thani Rajabhat University (No. Aor Wor 0622.7/365; 29 Jul. 2025).

The participants were 60 undergraduate EFL students and English language instructors from a public university (PU) and a private university (PVU) in Udon Thani province, with 30 students

from each institution selected via purposive sampling. Students were enrolled in academic writing courses during the first semester of the 2025 academic year. Purposive sampling was used because the study targeted EFL students with experience in academic writing and sought to compare writing produced in PU and PVU contexts. Each student wrote one essay of approximately 250–350 words on the topic, "In a global business context, how does politeness influence effective communication? Discuss how cultural differences shape perceptions of politeness and provide specific examples that illustrate how varying politeness norms can affect business interactions and outcomes. Students were given three hours to complete the task and were not permitted to use AI tools or dictionaries, resulting in a corpus of 60 essays totaling approximately 23,061 words. Five volunteer students and five English language instructors participated in semi-structured interviews.

Research Instruments

Three research instruments were: (1) a corpus of students' discussion essays providing authentic data; (2) semi-structured interview questions on language awareness, perceptions, and teaching practice, reviewed by three experts; and (3) AntConc software for analyzing frequencies, collocation patterns, and concordance analyses.

Data Collection

Before data collection, the researchers obtained permission from the participating universities and instructors. Students then wrote the essay, followed by semi-structured interviews with volunteer students and instructors, each lasting about 45 minutes. The researchers explained the study objectives, participants' rights, and confidentiality, and obtained written informed consent. All interviews were audio-recorded with permission and transcribed verbatim. To protect participants' identities, codes were used instead of real names: Public University (PU), Private University (PVU), Instructors (PU-T/PVU-T), and Students (PU-ST/PVU-ST).

Data Analysis

AntConc was used to analyze the data using Hyland's (2005) framework for interactional meta-discourse. Potential markers were identified with a search word list, and concordance lines were examined in context to exclude instances that did not function as meta-discourse. The identified markers were categorized as hedges, boosters, attitude markers, engagement markers, and self-mentions, and counts were calculated per 1,000 words. To enhance the validity and accuracy of the coding, three experts reviewed the identification and categorization of meta-discourse markers, and their comments informed the revision of the coding. Interview data were

transcribed, categorized, and qualitatively analyzed to examine participants' understanding, perceptions, challenges, and strategies in academic writing. Triangulation was used to compare the interview findings with the corpus–based results.

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Research Results

Table 1 Overall Results from data analysis of essays written by PU students and PVU students (N=60, PU=30, PVU = 30) (Total=23,061 words: PU = 11683; PVU = 11,378)

Essay	Hedges		Boosters		Attitude Markers		Engagement Markers		Self–mentions	
	PU	PVU	PU	PVU	PU	PVU	PU	PVU	PU	PVU
Total	225	228	136	124	75	71	244	231	608	578
Per/1000	19.26	20.04	11.64	10.90	6.42	6.24	20.89	20.30	52.04	50.80

Objective 1: Table 1 presents the use of interactional meta–discourse features in the PU and PVU corpora. Self–mentions were the most frequent features in both groups (PU = 52.04; PVU = 50.80 per 1,000 words), whereas attitude markers were the least frequent (PU = 6.42; PVU = 6.24). PU students used boosters more frequently than PVU students (PU = 11.64; PVU = 10.90), while the use of hedges and engagement markers was similar between the two groups (PU = 19.26; PVU = 20.04).

Table 2 The use of interactional meta–discourse in essays written by PU students and PVU students

Interactional Features	PU Key Resources (Token / 1,000)	PU (Token / 1,000)	PVU Key Resources (Token / 1,000)	PVU (Token / 1,000)
Hedges	Modal (96 / 8.22): may, might, could, should, would Adverbs (79 / 6.76): often, sometimes, about, around Verbs (37 / 3.17): feel(s), tend to, appear Adjectives (13 / 1.11): possible, likely, uncertain	225 / 19.26	Modal (72 / 6.33): may, might, would, should Adverbs (81 / 7.12): about, often, sometimes, probably Verbs (59 / 5.19): appear, feel(s), seems Adjectives (9 / 0.79): possible, unclear, uncertain	228 / 20.04

Interactional Features	PU Key Resources (Token / 1,000)	PU (Token / 1,000)	PVU Key Resources (Token / 1,000)	PVU (Token / 1,000)
Boosters	Verbs (89 / 7.62): think, know, show, believe; Adverbs (28 / 2.40): always, actually, certainly Modal (10 / 0.86): must Adjectives (9 / 0.77): clear, certain	136 / 11.64	Verbs (67 / 5.89): show, think(s), demonstrate(s) Adverbs (19 / 1.67): always, definitely Modal (11 / 0.97): must Adjectives (27 / 2.37): clear, certain, true	124 / 10.90
Attitude Markers	Adjectives (56 / 4.93): important, essential, appropriate; Adverbs (15 / 1.32): even, appropriately; Verbs (4 / 0.35): agree, prefer	75 / 6.42	Adjectives (60 / 5.28): important, essential, unexpected; Adverbs (10 / 0.88): even, importantly; Verbs (1 / 0.09): prefer	71 / 6.24
Engagement Markers	Verbs (155 / 13.27): use, show, allow, consider Pronouns (52 / 4.45): you, your Adjectives (21 / 1.80): one's, key Modal (3 / 0.26): should	244 / 20.89	Verbs (116 / 10.20): have to, see, develop Pronouns (97 / 8.53): you, our, us Modal (25 / 2.20): must, should Noun/Adj (13 / 1.14): key, one's	231 / 20.30
Self–mentions	Subject pronouns (308 / 26.36): I, we Possessive (209 / 17.89): my, our Object (91 / 7.79): me, us	608 / 52.04	Subject pronouns (274 / 24.08): I, we Possessive (227 / 19.95): my, our, mine Object (77 / 6.77): me, us	578 / 50.80

Objective 2. Table 2 showed the similarities and differences in the use of interpersonal resources across the PU and PVU corpora. Overall, self–mentions were the most frequent feature in both corpora, while attitude markers were the least frequent, followed by boosters, hedges, and engagement markers. The distributions of hedges and engagement markers were comparable across the two corpora. The PU corpus had a slightly higher rate than the PVU corpus (PU=608/52.04 per 1,000 words: PVU=578/50.80 per 1,000 words). The extensive use of subject pronouns (I and We) and possessive pronouns (my and our) was notable, suggesting that the students built an explicit authorial presence in their writing.

Engagement markers were also common in the PU and PVU corpora. PU students used these markers more often than PVU students (PU=244/20.89 per 1,000 words; PVU=231/20.30 per 1,000 words). Verbs (e.g., use, show, allow, and develop) were the dominant linguistic resources in both corpora. However, PVU students used more reader–oriented pronouns (you, our, us) and

modal verbs (must, should), suggesting they sought to engage readers more directly and guide their understanding.

Boosters were also used extensively in both corpora. In the PU essay, boosters were used more often than in the PVU essay (PU=136/11.64 per 1,000 words: PVU=124/10.90 per 1,000 words). Verbs such as think, know, show, and believe were common in both corpora. The results suggested that PU students tended to express greater certainty and authorial confidence when presenting arguments and claims.

The use of hedges in PU and PVU corpora was relatively similar (PU=225/19.26 per 1,000 words, PVU=228/20.04 per 1,000 words). The most common hedging devices were modal verbs and adverbs (e.g., may, might, often) and verbs (e.g., appear, seem), whereas the use of adjectives (e.g., possible, likely, unclear) was slightly different. This suggested that both PU and PVU students recognized the importance of cautious and tentative language in academic argumentation.

Finally, attitude markers were relatively rare in the PU and PVU corpora (PU=75/6.42 per 1,000 words; PVU=71/6.24 per 1,000 words). Adjectives (e.g., important, essential, and appropriate) were the predominant form. The results suggested that PU and PVU students were likely to focus on presenting arguments rather than on personal evaluation or affective stance in academic writing.

Objective 3. The qualitative results showed that participants had limited awareness and understanding of interactional features in academic writing. PU and PVU students were unfamiliar with the rhetorical functions and unintentionally used them in their essays. However, there were some differences. PU students were more likely to rely on instructors' models, examples in lessons, and patterns, whereas PVU students tended to focus on grammatical accuracy. For example, the PVU–ST2 noted, "I don't know the difference between hedging, boosters, or other terms. I have never really thought about it when writing. I just write what I think sounds good or what I feel is right for the topic.'

Regarding teaching, PU and PVU students strongly agreed that instructors should provide explicit instruction, clear explanations, authentic examples from academic texts, and interactive and collaborative learning activities. The instructors' feedback that helps students improve their writing was highlighted. The findings suggest that students need scaffolded instruction and practical guidance to develop awareness of and effective use of meta–discourse features in academic essays. For example, PU–ST1 said, "I think it would help if the instructor gave us many clear examples of

hedging and boosters in real academic articles. When I see how native speakers use them, I can learn to copy the style."

According to instructors' perspectives, both PU–T and PVU–T agreed that students were unaware of how to use interactional meta–discourse features in their essays. They further explained that students had basic writing skills, including grammar, vocabulary, sentence structure, and essay organization. Therefore, the use of these linguistic features was beyond students' proficiency levels. PU instructors noted that students were unaware of how to balance certainty and uncertainty in academic arguments. Furthermore, PVU instructors mostly emphasized clarity and structural organization rather than rhetorical stance–taking or reader engagement. Students not only used these linguistic features occasionally and accidentally, but they also produced repetitive or inappropriate expressions.

In addition, instructors from both PU and PVU noted that these linguistic features should be taught explicitly through scaffolded instruction. Model words, phrases, sentences, authentic academic texts, and guided exercises should be integrated into writing lessons and classroom practice. Furthermore, the instructors should provide comparative examples and short writing tasks, which were among the most effective techniques for helping students understand the persuasive and interpersonal functions of these linguistic features. For example, PVU–T5 noted, *"I take a step–by–step approach." I will first introduce the idea that writers can show doubt or confidence in their writing. Then, in later lessons, I add tasks that require students to include self–mentions or engage with the reader. For me, the key is to put these aspects into the lessons in a natural and progressive way, so that students gain confidence step by step."*

In conclusion, both instructors and students recognized the importance of meta–discourse features in academic writing. The findings highlighted limitations in students' rhetorical awareness and the need for systematic instructional support to enhance their effective use in EFL academic contexts.

Discussion

Research Question 1: Differences in the Frequency and Range of Interactional Meta–dis–course markers

Based on the results, both groups used a similar range of interactional markers, but PU students employed boosters more frequently, suggesting greater certainty and a more assertive

argumentative stance. This difference may reflect institutional writing practices or classroom expectations that encourage stronger claims. The finding supports Karahan (2022) and Rozina and Karapetjana, who argue that rhetorical choices vary across educational contexts rather than depending solely on linguistic competence. In contrast, attitude markers appeared infrequently in both groups, indicating that students associated academic writing with objectivity and avoided overt evaluation, consistent with Hyland (2005) and Hooi et al. (2020). Both groups also used engagement markers and self–mentions to address readers and construct authorial identity. Overall, while PU and PVU students showed similar awareness of interactional metadiscourse, differences in the frequency of specific markers, especially boosters, reflected variation in rhetorical positioning shaped by institutional learning contexts.exts.

Research Question 2: Differences in the Degree of Commitment Expressed in Interactional Metadiscourse

Both groups used hedges at comparable levels, indicating an awareness of the need to avoid absolute claims and to negotiate knowledge appropriately in academic writing. This supports Dewi et al. (2024) and Liu (2024), who identify hedging as an important strategy for expressing uncertainty while maintaining academic credibility. However, PU students used boosters more frequently, indicating stronger epistemic commitment, whereas PVU students adopted a more cautious rhetorical style. This suggests that degrees of commitment may be shaped not only by individual preference but also by instructional practices and institutional expectations in argumentative writing. The limited use of attitude markers in both groups further indicates a preference for objectivity over explicit personal evaluation, consistent with Hyland (2005) and Chen et al. In contrast, PVU students used engagement markers more often, suggesting greater attention to reader involvement. Both groups also relied heavily on self–mentions to establish authorial presence and claim ownership of ideas, possibly reflecting an effort to balance individual identity with the interpersonal harmony valued in Thai educational culture.

Research Question 3: Pedagogical Strategies for Enhancing Students' Use of Epistemic Modality

The interview findings revealed that writing instruction primarily emphasized grammar, vocabulary, sentence structure, and organization, whereas interactional meta–discourse was rarely taught explicitly. Consequently, students often used interactional markers unconsciously, treating familiar expressions such as I think and in my opinion as habitual language rather than as deliberate

rhetorical strategies. This finding supports Incharoensak and Gampper, 2019, who argues that English instruction in Thailand tends to emphasize linguistic accuracy over discourse–level rhetorical awareness. The interview data also suggest two major pedagogical implications. First, interactional metadiscourse should be explicitly integrated into academic writing instruction. Direct explanation of the forms, functions, and rhetorical purposes of hedges, boosters, attitude markers, engagement markers, and self–mentions can help students understand how these resources express certainty, construct persuasive arguments, and engage readers more effectively (Chen et al., 2025; Incharoensak & Gampper, 2019). Second, instruction should be scaffolded from basic to more advanced writing tasks. Students should first identify and practice interactional markers in model texts, then apply them to paragraph and essay writing while receiving systematic feedback. This gradual approach helps learners develop rhetorical awareness and use interactional meta–discourse confidently in academic writing, supporting the scaffolding approach proposed by Ritonga et al.

Conclusion

The present study examined the use of interactional meta–discourse in argumentative essays written by PU and PVU EFL students in Udon Thani Province. Overall, the results showed that students were similarly aware of the use of interactional meta–discourse resources. However, it should be noted that PU students tended to adopt a more assertive stance, particularly boosters, whereas PVU students were likely to employ engagement markers in their essays. Significantly, the interview data revealed that PU and PVU students used these linguistic features unconsciously and unintentionally, influenced by casual expressions such as "I think" and "in my opinion" used in everyday communication, rather than by an intentional use of them as interactional strategies with readers. This is because the lessons on interactional meta–discourse were implicit in the writing instruction. Therefore, the study proposed integrating explicit and scaffolded instruction in interactional meta–discourse to promote students' rhetorical awareness, stance construction, and argumentative writing in academic contexts.

Suggestions

For classroom practice

Based on the present study, the instructors should integrate the interactional features into the lessons and teach them explicitly so that students can understand how to express certainty,

engage readers, and establish authorial identity in writing. As for scaffolded instruction, the instructors should have students recall and identify the functions of meta–discourse markers from concordance examples; compare assertive statements with appropriately hedged versions; complete paragraph–revision exercises using hedges, boosters, and engagement markers; use a rubric to assess stance, reader engagement, and appropriateness; and conduct pre– and post–instruction activities to examine the effects of explicit instruction.

For further research

Further research should: (1) include larger and more diverse groups of EFL students across institutions, disciplines, and proficiency levels; (2) broaden the focus to other categories, such as transitions, frame markers, or evidentials, to provide a more complete picture of how students use meta–discourse in academic writing; and (3) examine the long–term effects of explicit and scaffolded instruction. Longitudinal designs would help determine whether students can effectively use meta–discourse in writing tasks, academic courses, or professional contexts.

New Knowledge

This corpus analysis and qualitative data offer a comprehensive understanding of EFL students' use of interactional features. The results imply that it is essential to raise students' awareness of these interactional features. Importantly, regarding the new body of knowledge obtained from the study, the present study highlights the integration of this knowledge into academic writing lessons and scaffolded instruction as follows:

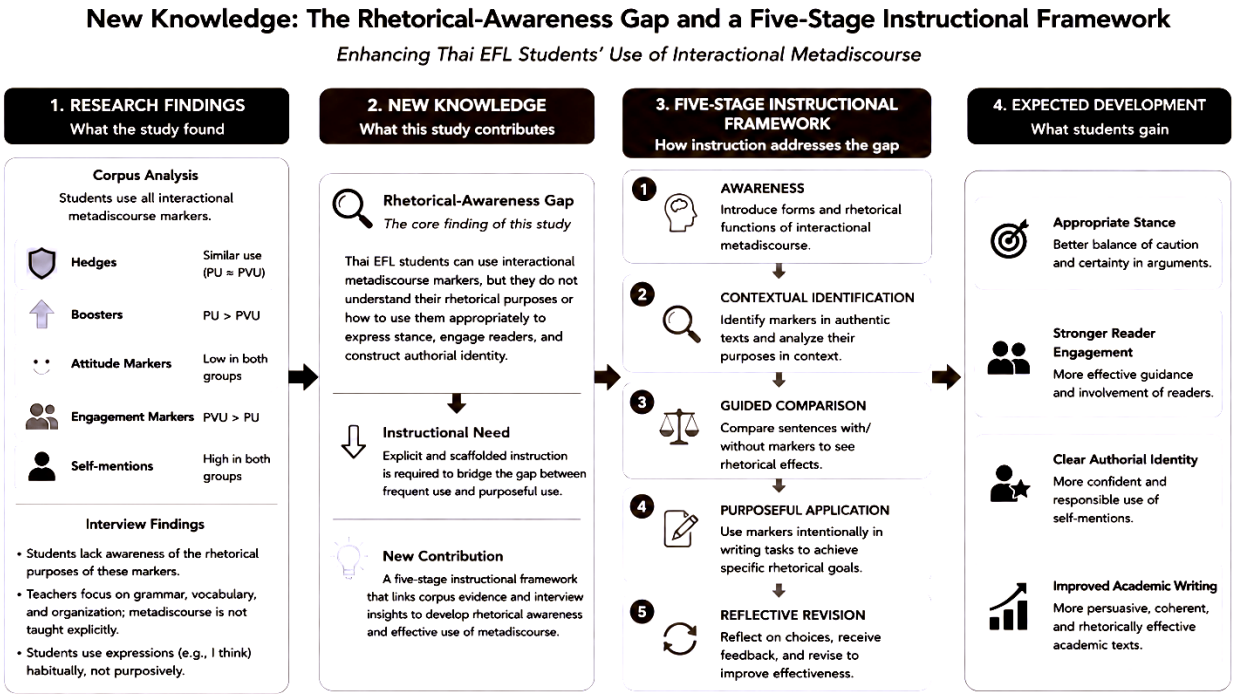


Figure 1 Pedagogical Implications: Guidelines for Teaching Interactional Meta–discourse to EFL learners

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